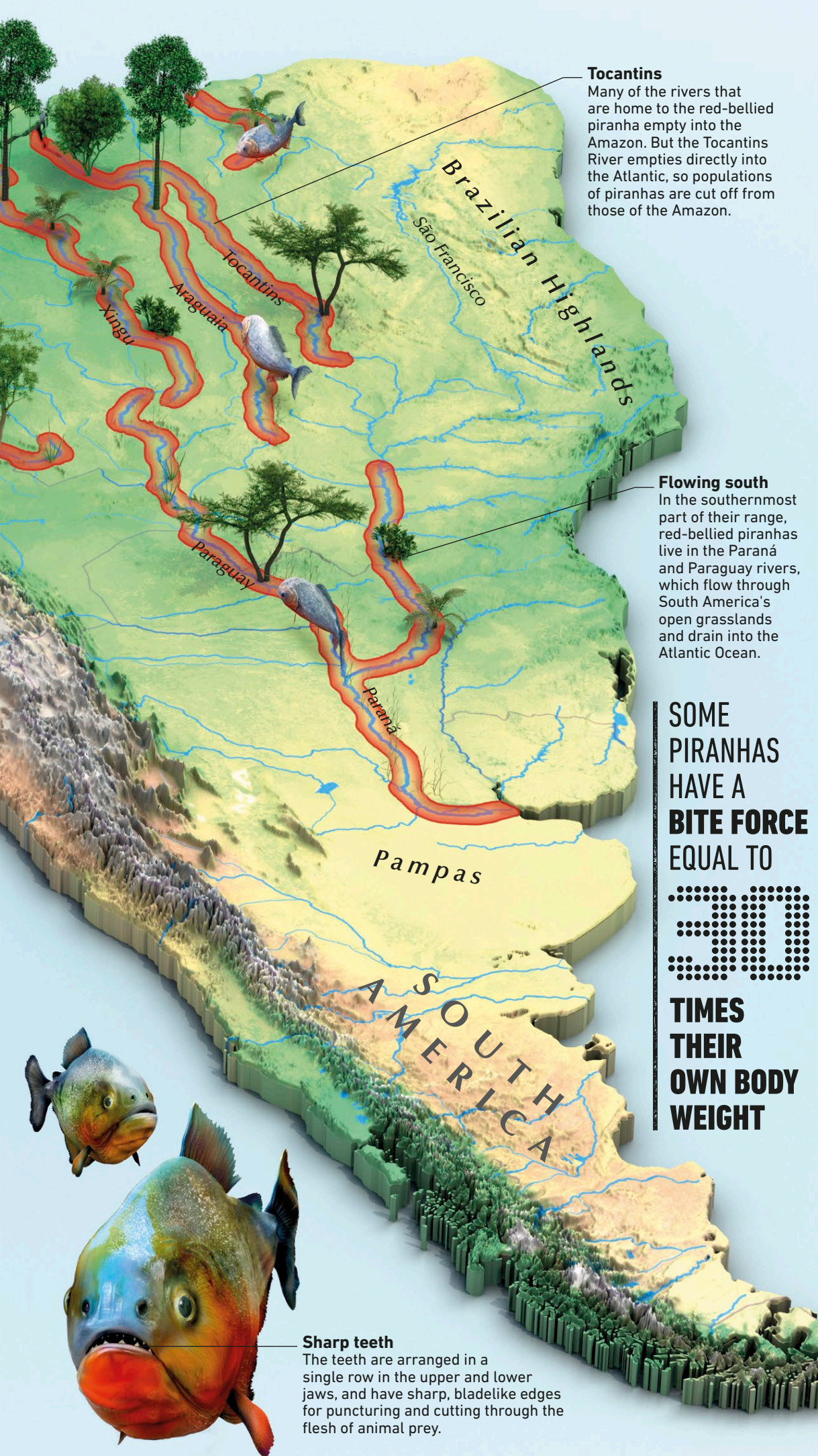




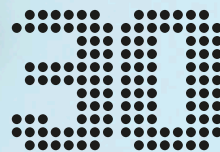
Tocantins

Many of the rivers that are home to the red-bellied piranha empty into the Amazon. But the Tocantins River empties directly into the Atlantic, so populations of piranhas are cut off from those of the Amazon.

Flowing south

In the southernmost part of their range, red-bellied piranhas live in the Paraná and Paraguay rivers, which flow through South America's open grasslands and drain into the Atlantic Ocean.

**SOME
PIRANHAS
HAVE A
BITE FORCE
EQUAL TO**



**TIMES
THEIR
OWN BODY
WEIGHT**

Sharp teeth

The teeth are arranged in a single row in the upper and lower jaws, and have sharp, bladelike edges for puncturing and cutting through the flesh of animal prey.

PIRANHA RELATIVES



Pacu

A giant relative of the piranhas, the pacu has strong jaws for cracking seeds and nuts that fall into the waters when the Amazon is flooded during the rainy season.



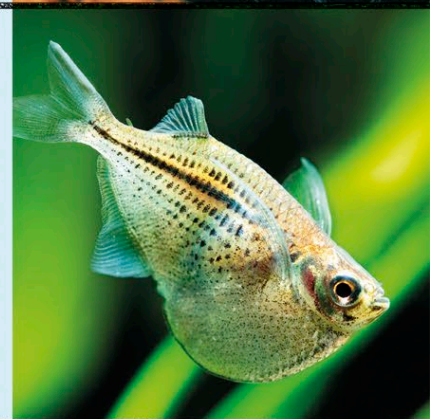
Neon tetra

Tetras are tiny relatives of the piranhas that eat small invertebrates. Many, such as the neon tetra, are brightly colored—making them popular in aquariums.



Freshwater hatchetfish

Small piranha relatives called hatchetfishes swim near the surface and prey on insects. Their muscular bodies help them jump from the water to escape danger.



African tiger fish

Close cousins of the piranhas live across the Atlantic in African rivers. Some, such as the African tiger fish, are also sharp-toothed meat-eaters.



Congo tetra

The brightly colored Congo tetra lives in Africa. These ancestors of piranha relatives first evolved when South America and Africa were joined.

